

Website Design Brief

Heron Constructive Solutions Ltd

A practical guide for the design team:
the goal, the audience, the imagery, the words, and the plan.

The Goal

What this website has to do, in one page

Heron Constructive Solutions is an **external works and landscaping contractor** — fencing, gates, paving, communal areas, estate improvements — working for **housing associations and councils** such as Plus Dane and Knowsley Council.

Our clients don't find contractors by browsing the web. They find us through tender portals, frameworks and word of mouth — and **then** they visit the website to check we're real, established and safe to hire. The website's job is to pass that inspection.

The one-sentence goal: when a housing association or council officer looks us up after a tender, the website should remove every doubt — and give them one more reason to shortlist us.

What that means in practice

- The site is **evidence, not advertising**. Every page should prove something: real projects, real partners, real people, real accreditations.
- It must look **finished and professional**. Right now the live site is a holding page and the draft pages still contain template placeholder text and fake statistics. A council officer who sees “lorem ipsum” closes the tab — an unfinished site is worse than a simple one.
- It should speak the client's language (see The Words, page 3) and show our actual work (see The Pictures, page 4).
- It needs to be found for the right searches — “fencing contractor Knowsley”, “estate improvement contractor Merseyside” (see SEO, page 5).

Our strongest cards — play them prominently

- **Named partners:** Plus Dane and Knowsley Council logos, with permission, on the homepage.
- **Social value:** our Jobs Plus partnership with Travis Perkins. Councils are legally required to weigh social value when they buy — most competitors have nothing like this. It belongs on the homepage, not buried on a services page.
- **Visible transformations:** external works photograph brilliantly. Before/after pairs are our proof.

The Audience

Design every page for these four readers

Who	What they're doing on our site	What they need to see
Procurement officers (councils & housing associations)	Due diligence after we've applied to a tender or framework. They're checking we're legitimate and low-risk.	Accreditations, insurance, years trading, named clients, a finished professional site.
Asset managers / heads of property services	Deciding whether to invite us to quote for estate improvements, fencing programmes, communal upgrades.	Case studies at estate scale, services described in their vocabulary, proof we deliver on time.
Contract administrators & surveyors	Sizing up what we're like to work with day-to-day.	Signs we understand occupied estates: tidy sites, tenant liaison, uniformed and badged operatives.
Residents	They've had a letter saying we're coming to work on their street or garden, and they've looked us up.	Reassurance: who we are, ID badges, DBS-checked staff, how to contact us with a concern.

Design test for every page: "Would a procurement officer trust this? Would a resident feel reassured by it?" If a page doesn't serve one of the four readers above, it doesn't need to exist.

What this audience is not

They are not homeowners dreaming about extensions, and they are not impressed by glossy lifestyle imagery or marketing superlatives. Public-sector buyers are professionally sceptical — they've been burned by contractors who overpromise. Calm, plain and specific always beats bold and salesy for this audience.

The Words

Voice, tone and vocabulary — for anyone writing or placing copy

Voice principles

- **Evidence over adjectives.** “Approved contractor for Plus Dane” beats a paragraph about our passion for excellence.
- **Calm and plain.** Short sentences. First person plural (“we”). No hype, no exclamation marks.
- **Their vocabulary, not homeowner vocabulary.** Use the terms that appear in tenders — they signal we’ve done this work before, and they’re also exactly what people search for (see SEO).

Say this	Not this
External works and landscaping contractor for social housing	Construction company for all your building needs
Estate and environmental improvements	Transform your outdoor space
Fencing and gates • communal areas • paths and paving • boundary treatments • accessibility works (ramps, handrails)	Bespoke garden makeovers
Working in occupied properties, with resident liaison	Hassle-free service
47 gardens re-fenced across the estate in six weeks, no missed appointments	Unrivalled quality and craftsmanship

Content that must be written (currently missing or placeholder)

- **About page:** mission, values and story sections are still template lorem ipsum, and the statistics are the template’s fake numbers (“44 million jobs”, “\$119 trillion”). These must be replaced or removed before anything else — they are credibility poison.
- **Accreditations & compliance section:** Constructionline / CHAS / SafeContractor / SMAS memberships, insurance, health & safety approach — even a short version. This is the first thing procurement looks for.
- **“How we work on your estate”:** a short page or section covering resident liaison, DBS-checked and badged operatives, tidy sites and complaints handling.
- **Jobs Plus / social value:** promote from the services page to the homepage, with a plain-English explanation of what it delivers locally.

The Pictures

Before/after pairs, told as project stories

Our photographic asset is the **before/after pair** — perfect for external works, where the whole transformation is visible from one camera position.

The golden rule

Same spot, same angle, same framing for every pair. Matched pairs read as proof; mismatched pairs read as marketing. Photograph the “before” on day one — the honest, messy before shot is what makes the after credible.

Shooting checklist

- Landscape orientation; mid-morning or mid-afternoon light; similar weather across the pair where possible.
- Include context in frame — the house, the boundary, the street — not just close-ups of new fencing. Readers need to recognise real social housing stock.
- A few “during” shots per project: operatives in branded PPE with ID badges, liveried vans, tidy site. One “during” image quietly answers “what are they like to have on site?”
- Permissions are a standard step: property permission for every shot, and never an identifiable person (especially children) without written consent.

How each project story is structured

- **Header:** client + location + scope — “Fencing renewal, Plus Dane estate, Knowsley”.
- **Before photo** + one sentence on the problem (worn, unsafe, fly-tipping, resident complaints).
- **After photo** from the identical position.
- **Three facts:** duration • delivered on a live, occupied estate • social value element (local labour, resident consultation).
- **One quote** from a housing officer or resident, if we can get it.

Estate-wide stories beat single gardens

“47 gardens re-fenced across the estate in six weeks” persuades a council far more than one beautiful garden, because it proves we deliver at **programme scale** — exactly what frameworks buy. Where a project covers a whole estate, design the story at that scale: a set of pairs plus the headline numbers.

Where the pictures live

- **Homepage:** our three strongest matched pairs, each linking to its full project story.
- **Case studies page:** the project story library, one story per project in the format above.
- **Services page:** one real pair per service — no stock photos anywhere; procurement people spot stock imagery instantly and it reads as “nothing real to show”.

SEO, Without the Jargon

How design decisions decide whether we get found

SEO (search engine optimisation) is simply: **when someone searches for what we do, in the places we work, our site should appear**. Most of it is not technical — it's decided by the words and structure you choose while designing pages. Here's what matters, in order.

1. One page per service, named the way people search

Google ranks *pages*, not websites. A single “Our Services” page competes for nothing; a page called **“Fencing & Gates for Housing Associations”** can rank for exactly that search. Design the services section as separate pages: fencing & gates • communal area improvements • paths & paving • estate improvements • accessibility works.

2. Place names on the page

Our searches are local: “fencing contractor Knowsley”, “external works Merseyside”. Every case study should name its location, and the site should say plainly where we work (Liverpool, Knowsley, Merseyside, the North West). The footer should carry the full company name, address and phone number on every page — this also feeds Google Maps results.

3. Headings are signposts, not decoration

Each page gets **one main heading** that says what the page is about in plain words (“Estate fencing programmes for housing associations”), with subheadings that break up the content logically. Google reads headings first — so does a person skimming.

4. Every image needs a text description (“alt text”)

A one-line description of what's in the photo: “New timber fencing on a Plus Dane estate in Knowsley — after”. It's how Google understands our before/after pairs, how partially sighted visitors experience them, and a legal expectation for public-sector-facing sites. Build it into the design handover: no image ships without its description.

5. Page titles — the words on the browser tab

Each page needs a unique title in the form **“What it is | Heron Constructive Solutions”** — e.g. “Fencing & Gates for Housing Associations | Heron Constructive Solutions”. This is the blue headline people see in Google results, so write it for a human deciding whether to click.

6. Fast pages — which for us means photo sizes

Google demotes slow sites, and ours will be photo-heavy. Export every image for web (rule of thumb: under ~300KB, sized to how large it actually appears). A beautiful 8MB photo straight off the phone will quietly sink its page.

The good news: everything above is a by-product of doing the design properly. Real words, real place names, clear headings, described images, lean photos — no tricks, no plugins, no “SEO magic” needed.

Craft Standards

What “properly built” means for this site

Works everywhere our audience is

Housing officers browse from desktop at work; residents look us up on phones. Every page must work at phone width first — nothing cut off, nothing requiring sideways scrolling, buttons big enough for thumbs. Check each design at phone, tablet and desktop widths before calling it done.

Accessible by default

- Public-sector clients take accessibility seriously — their own sites must meet WCAG standards, and they notice when suppliers' sites don't.
- Strong colour contrast (our maroon on white passes; light grey text on white often doesn't — check anything subtle).
- Text is real text, never baked into images. Every image has its description. Links say where they go (“See the Knowsley fencing project”, not “click here”).

Consistent and calm

- One brand palette throughout: maroon (#8B2332) as primary, green (#3D8B37) as accent, charcoal for text. The green is a natural fit for landscaping work — use it for highlights, ticks and the social-value story.
- One or two typefaces, a consistent grid, generous white space. Restraint reads as professionalism to this audience.

No dead ends, no leftovers

- Every button and link goes somewhere real — the current draft has “Get started” buttons that link to nothing. Broken links on day one undo everything else.
- Zero placeholder content ships. No lorem ipsum, no template statistics, no placeholder.co images, no template values like “Enjoy downtime”.
- Contact details identical everywhere: 0151 475 1217 • info@heroncs.co.uk • full company name and registered details in the footer.

Every page earns its place

A small, finished site beats a large, half-finished one. Launch with five solid pages — Home, Services, Case Studies, About, Contact — and grow the case study library over time. Anything that can't be finished to standard for launch gets cut, not shipped half-done.

The Plan

Six steps to launch — and what each one wins us

The site needs to be live as soon as possible, so the steps are ordered by **credibility per day of effort**: each step makes the site launchable at a higher standard than the last. Steps 1–2 are days, not weeks — and only photography (step 3) depends on site visits, so start it in parallel on day one.

1

Clear the decks

Remove every trace of template: lorem ipsum values, fake statistics, placeholder images, dead “Get started” links. Fix contact details site-wide.

GOALPOST: the site could go live tomorrow without embarrassing us. Nothing on it is untrue.

2

Write the real words

Rewrite Home and About in the voice on page 3: external works positioning, the four audiences, evidence over adjectives. Draft the accreditations section and “How we work on your estate”.

GOALPOST: a procurement officer reading any page believes we've delivered social housing contracts before.

3

Shoot the photography (start day one, runs in parallel)

Matched-angle before/after pairs on current and recent jobs, plus “during” shots (branded PPE, vans, tidy sites). Collect permissions as you go. Export everything web-sized.

GOALPOST: every placeholder image has a real replacement that proves we do this work.

4

Build the project stories

Assemble 2–3 case studies in the page-4 format: header, before/after pair, three facts, quote. Prioritise one estate-scale story. Put the three best pairs on the homepage; move Jobs Plus and the partner logos up.

GOALPOST: we have shortlist-winning proof: real clients, real estates, real transformations, real social value.

5

Structure for search

Split services into one page per service with search-friendly names, place names throughout, unique page titles, alt text on every image, full contact footer.

GOALPOST: Google can rank us for “fencing contractor Knowsley” and every service we sell. LAUNCH: replace the holding page.

6

Polish and grow (post-launch)

Phone/tablet/desktop pass, contrast and accessibility check, page-speed check on photo-heavy pages. Then a standing habit: every completed project adds one new before/after story.

GOALPOST: the site meets public-sector expectations — and gets stronger with every job we finish.

Definition of done for launch (end of step 5): five finished pages • zero placeholders • real before/after photography • 2–3 project stories • accreditations visible • Jobs Plus on the homepage • works on a phone • every image described • every link live.